

By **Dipankar Gupta**

The author is an eminent sociologist who taught at Jawaharlal Nehru University for three decades

The Compliance Conundrum

Indians know civic responsibility but often don't practise it. This survey reveals the disconnect between awareness and real-world behaviour

This survey comes to two important conclusions. First, most people in India know what the right thing is to do and then don't do it. Second, the southern states, particularly Kerala, are way ahead of the North in terms of civic consciousness. This includes a host of factors covering a wide spectrum. They stretch from awareness of public cleanliness, religious tolerance, banning tobacco, neighbourhood safety and, most striking of all, gender parity.

Like most surveys, one has to read this one too between the numbers, keeping in mind the many limitations that such exercises chronically suffer from. The most common one is that the very act of asking questions gives the game away and the responses then are, as if, rehearsed. The respondents are conscious that they are being judged and accordingly reply in ways that would make them look good.

On the face of it, some of the findings seem controvertible, but if a long view is taken, then the figures tell us an interesting story. Here, two quick illustrations will suffice. This survey records that 99 per cent of the respondents in Delhi say ticketless travel is bad, or that 86 per cent disapprove of littering in public places, but everyday experiences on both these issues are very different.

Likewise, 87 per cent of the respondents believe that it is wrong to tamper with electricity meters or that 88 per cent say they would stop to call the police or ambulance should they come across a serious accident. Yes, these figures are questionable, but what emerges through this thicket of numbers is that people know that littering or tampering with meters or travelling ticketless is wrong. But why then are their actions not in concordance with their statements?

There is no doubt now that the broad lessons in civics are comprehensively known. Even something that is often castigated as an elite concern, namely, climate change, is actually fairly well perceived among the general populace (as many as 69 per cent across India). Yet, if we surrender to these numbers without caution and go strictly by what the respondents report, we would be deluding ourselves and missing out on the big story, which is far more instructive.

The issue clearly is that if correct norms of public behaviour have been articulated or understood, why then do most people flout them in practice? Before this survey, one calmly assumed that so many of us just did not know what was proper and civil and, therefore, we thought there was a mammoth task ahead of us to educate the ignorant masses. This survey tells us that such a conclusion is simply not true. The people of India do not need lessons in public ethics, what they need are enforcers in that department.

Enforcement and not moralising is the need of the day. The task ahead is to make people do what they say they do

To this end, the INDIA TODAY survey has adroitly accompanied many of its findings with nationwide statistics from other sources that tell us about actual public behaviour. This positions the stark contrast between what people say they do and what they actually do. If 88 per cent of the respondents did, in fact, stop and report a serious accident, as they record they would, why then does the ministry of transport report that 50 per cent of fatali-

For the detailed report, please scan the QR code